

BENIN EMPIRE



ESTABLISHED IN THE 11TH CENTURY, Benin was a powerful West African kingdom which flourished in the forests west of the River Niger.

The wealth of Benin was based on trading: trans-Saharan trade with African savannah kingdoms, which linked the Benin Empire with the Mediterranean and the Middle East, and, coastal trade with Europeans. Benin's obas, or kings, controlled the trade networks. Immensely powerful, they lived in the royal palace in the capital city of Benin. In 1897, the British conquered Benin and ended the empire.

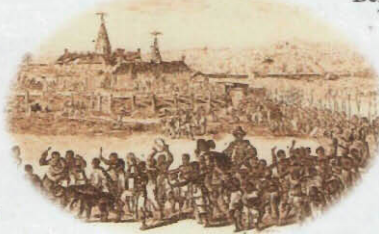
Empire boundaries

The Benin Empire was in modern Nigeria, where Benin City now stands. Both it and the modern republic west of Nigeria take their name from the old empire.



Benin City

The empire of Benin was centred on the impressive capital, Benin City. A wide road ran through the centre, and a huge earthenwork wall surrounded the city. The wall acted as a defence and would have taken some considerable time to build. Its size stood as a symbol of the influence held by Benin's oba. The city housed the oba's royal palace, and areas called wards where the craftspeople lived.



Engraving of Benin City

Craft guilds

Guilds of craftspeople, such as leather workers, blacksmiths, drummers, weavers, carpenters, ivory carvers, and brass casters lived in Benin City. The brass casters formed one of the most important guilds. They made the distinctive "bronze" heads and plaques for the royal palace.



Spikes to support ivory carving

Only obas wore neck rings.

Bronze head

Benin "bronze" heads are actually made of brass. They commemorated dead obas and their family members, court ceremonies – even European traders. Carved ivory adorned the heads, which were kept in shrines in the royal palace.

Memorial head of an oba



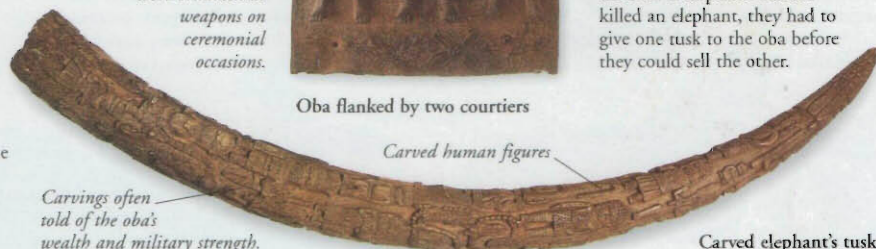
Obas and courtiers wore ornamental weapons on ceremonial occasions.

Brass plaques

Carved plaques decorated the wooden pillars that supported the oba's palace roof. They depicted court life and important events, such as the presentation of gifts from the oba to his courtiers.

Ivory carving

Ornately carved ivory tusks were among Benin's luxury goods. All trade in ivory was controlled by the oba. If elephant hunters killed an elephant, they had to give one tusk to the oba before they could sell the other.



Oba flanked by two courtiers

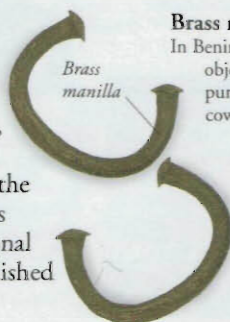
Carved human figures

Carved elephant's tusk

Carvings often told of the oba's wealth and military strength.

Trade

For centuries, Benin traded with African kingdoms to the north, including the Songhai Empire. The arrival of the Europeans in the 1400s disrupted these traditional relationships and established new trading outlets.



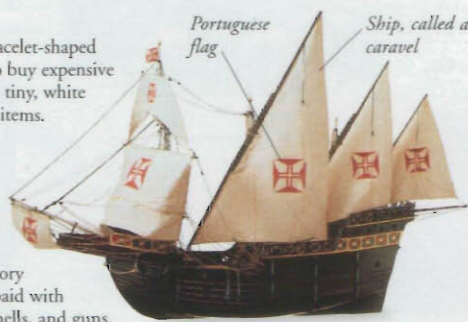
Brass manilla

Brass manillas

In Benin, merchants used bracelet-shaped objects called manillas to buy expensive purchases, but they used tiny, white cowrie shells for smaller items.

Merchants

Travelling by sea, Portuguese traders bought slaves, peppers, cloth, gold, and ivory from Benin, and paid with manillas, cowrie shells, and guns.



Portuguese flag

Ship, called a caravel

British conquest

In 1897, in revenge for an attack on a British party, the British burnt and looted Benin City, exiled the oba, and brought Benin under colonial rule.



Oba Ewuare the Great

The warrior-king Ewuare (r.1440–80) rebuilt Benin City and, under his rule, the surrounding territory reached its greatest extent. Ewuare also established a tradition of secure hereditary succession.



Ewuare's leopard-shaped arm ornament

Timeline

11th century Benin Empire founded in the forests of Nigeria.

1450 Peak of Benin Empire.

1486 First European to visit Benin is Portuguese explorer, Afonso d'Aveiro; shortly afterward a Benin chief establishes a trading store for the Portuguese.



Benin ornamental sword

1500s English, Dutch, and French merchants start to trade with Benin Empire.

Early to mid-16th century King of Portugal sends Christian missionaries to Benin to convert Oba Esigie, and build churches.

1688 Dutchman Olfert Dapper writes a history of Benin.

1700s Empire weakened by succession struggles.

1897 Britain takes Benin City by force.

1960 Nigeria, including the old Benin Empire, gains independence.

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